Basic Linux Commands - Beginner Cheat Sheet

40 essential commands for students, developers, testers and DevOps beginners.

No.	Command	Purpose	Example
1	**pwd**	Show current directory	pwd
2	**ls**	List files and folders	ls
3	**ls -l**	Detailed file listing	ls -l
4	**ls -a**	Show hidden files	ls -a
5	**cd**	Change directory	cd Documents
6	**cd ..**	Go to parent directory	cd ..
7	**cd ~**	Go to home directory	cd ~
8	**mkdir**	Create directory	mkdir project
9	**rmdir**	Remove empty directory	rmdir project
10	**touch**	Create empty file	touch test.txt
11	**cat**	Show file contents	cat test.txt
12	**nano**	Edit text file	nano test.txt
13	**cp**	Copy file	cp a.txt b.txt
14	**mv**	Move or rename file	mv a.txt b.txt
15	**rm**	Delete file	rm test.txt
16	**rm -r**	Delete directory and contents	rm -r project
17	**clear**	Clear terminal screen	clear
18	**echo**	Print text	echo "Hello Linux"
19	**whoami**	Show current username	whoami
20	**date**	Show current date/time	date
21	**cal**	Show calendar (if installed)	cal
22	**history**	Show command history	history
23	**man**	Read command manual	man ls
24	**head**	Show first lines	head -n 5 test.txt
25	**tail**	Show last lines	tail -n 5 test.txt
26	**grep**	Search text	grep "error" app.log
27	**find**	Find files	find . -name "*.txt"
28	**wc**	Count lines, words, bytes	wc test.txt
29	**sort**	Sort lines	sort names.txt
30	**chmod**	Change file permissions	chmod 755 script.sh

No.	Command	Purpose	Example
31	**chown**	Change ownership	sudo chown user file.txt
32	**ps**	Show processes	ps aux
33	**top**	Monitor processes	top
34	**kill**	Send signal to process	kill 1234
35	**df -h**	Show disk space	df -h
36	**du -sh**	Show directory size	du -sh project
37	**free -h**	Show memory usage	free -h
38	**ping**	Test network connectivity	ping google.com
39	**curl**	Request an HTTP endpoint	curl http://localhost:8000
40	**sudo**	Run with elevated privileges	sudo apt update

Hands-on practice

```
pwd
mkdir LinuxTraining
cd LinuxTraining
touch student.txt
echo "Welcome to Linux" > student.txt
cat student.txt
cp student.txt backup.txt
ls -l
mv backup.txt student_backup.txt
rm student_backup.txt
cd ..
rm LinuxTraining/student.txt
rmdir LinuxTraining
```

Safety: Be careful with rm, rm -r, chmod, chown and sudo. Deleted files may not be recoverable. The example removes the remaining student.txt before using rmdir.